

A KITCHEN-TABLE GUIDE

Essential Spanish

*For English-speaking retirees
living in Panama*

You don't need to be fluent. You need to be understood.

Not a textbook. A practical booklet you can keep on the table,
open at the farmacia, and sneak a look at in the taxi.

Latin American Spanish · Usted-friendly · Panama examples



Keep it close. Use what you need. Nobody is giving you a quiz.

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Skip around. The booklet is built for looking things up, not for reading cover to cover.

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How to use this booklet

This is not a school textbook. It is a kitchen-table guide for real life in Panama: the farmacia, the clinic, the mercado, the taxi, and the neighbor who waters your plants when you fly home to see the grandkids.

Spanish looks like a mountain from far away. Up close, you only need a few paths. This booklet is those paths. Skip around. Dog-ear the pages you actually use. Nobody is giving you a quiz.

A simple way to use it

- 1 Skim the first half once so the ideas sound familiar.
- 2 Save the web version on your phone. Print the phrase pages if you like paper.
- 3 When you get stuck, flip to the pattern you need — not the whole book.
- 4 Say the sentences out loud. Spanish gets friendlier once your mouth has practiced it.

If you remember nothing else

Smile. Say **por favor** and **gracias**. Use **usted** with people you don't know well. And the magic phrase: **Más despacio, por favor.** — A little slower, please.

Panama Spanish, in one paragraph

People here speak Latin American Spanish. They do not use Spain's **vosotros**. The safe word for “you” with strangers, shopkeepers, doctors, and officials is **usted**. Friends may switch to **tú** — follow their lead. And yes, the money is already in dollars. You can skip that particular headache.

What actually trips English speakers

The splits English does not make are the ones that last: two ways to say “to be” (especially **estar**), two past tenses, and little words like **lo** and **la**. Mixing up **ser** and **estar**, or using the wrong past, is what most often confuses a listener. A wrong **el** or **la** almost never does.

Mistakes are allowed. Panamanians deal with visitors from everywhere, and a kind attempt almost always beats perfect silence. If someone answers you in English, take the help. You can still sneak in a **gracias** on the way out.

CHAPTER 1

Fifteen sentences that do a lot of work

If you only learn one page, make it this one. These sentences will get you through greetings, shops, confusion, and a polite goodbye.

Spanish	How it sounds	English
Hola. Buenos días.	OH-lah. BWEH-nohs DEE-ahs	Hi. Good morning.
¿Cómo está usted?	KOH-moh es-TAH oos-TED	How are you? (polite)
Me llamo...	meh YAH-moh	My name is...
Mucho gusto.	MOO-choh GOO-stoh	Nice to meet you.
No hablo español muy bien.	no AH-bloh es-pah-NYOL mwee BYEN	I don't speak Spanish very well.
¿Habla inglés?	AH-blah een-GLEHS	Do you speak English?
Más despacio, por favor.	MAHS des-PAH-syoh por fah-VOR	A little slower, please.
No entiendo.	no en-TYEN-doh	I don't understand.
¿Puede repetir, por favor?	PWEH-deh reh-peh-TEER	Can you repeat that, please?
¿Me puede ayudar?	meh PWEH-deh ah-yoo-DAR	Can you help me?
¿Cuánto cuesta?	KWAHN-toh KWEH-stah	How much does it cost?
Quiero esto, por favor.	KYEH-roh ES-toh por fah-VOR	I want this, please.
¿Dónde está el baño?	DOHN-deh es-TAH el BAH-nyoh	Where is the bathroom?
Me duele aquí.	meh DWEH-leh ah-KEE	It hurts here. (point)
Gracias. Que le vaya bien.	GRAH-syahs. keh leh VAH-yah BYEN	Thank you. Take care.

Pointing is a strategy

Hold up the thing, the bottle, the address on your phone. **Esto, por favor** (this, please) plus a finger will carry you farther than a perfect verb chart.

CHAPTER 2

How Spanish sounds

Here is the best news in this whole booklet: Spanish is mostly phonetic. Once the sounds are in your ear, you can read a menu out loud and be close enough.

The five vowels never really change

English vowels wander all over the place. Spanish vowels stay home. Learn these five and a lot of words suddenly look readable.

Letter	Say it like	Example
a	ah in father	casa, Panamá
e	eh in bet (clear, not “ay”)	café, mesa
i	ee in machine	sí, vino
o	oh in go, but shorter	hola, doctor
u	oo in moon	tú, uno

The consonants that surprise English speakers

Letter	What to do	Example
h	Always silent.	hola (OH-lah)
j	A strong h, from the throat.	José, jardín
ll / y	In Panama, both sound like y in yes.	calle, playa
ñ	ny, as in canyon.	mañana, señor
r	A quick tap (like the tt in butter, American-style).	pero, caro
rr	A trill. Do your best. People will still understand you.	perro, arroz
v / b	Almost the same sound. Don't stress the difference.	vaca, banco
qu	A k sound. The u is silent.	qué, quiero
c + e/i, or z	An s sound in Panama (not Spain's th sound).	cielo, cerveza
g + e/i	Same raspy h as j.	gente, giro

Two extra spelling notes: **gue** and **gui** have a silent u (**guitarra**). And **qué, cuál, cómo, dónde, cuándo, quién** take an accent when they are questions.

Where the stress goes

- If there is an accent mark, stress that syllable: **café, teléfono, Panamá.**
- No accent, and the word ends in a vowel, n, or s? Stress the second-to-last syllable: **casa, hablan, lunes.**
- No accent, and it ends in any other consonant? Stress the last syllable: **doctor, hotel, español.**

Skip the rolled r if you have to

The sound that marks you as English is usually the vowels — keep them short and pure, not “no-uh” or “day-ee.” A weak rolled **rr** almost never blocks meaning. A swallowed vowel sometimes does.

What your ear will notice here

Along the coast, a final **s** can sound soft or almost disappear. **Más o menos** might sound like “mah o meno.” You did not go deaf. That is just Panama talking — and it can hide plurals when you listen. In the highlands (Boquete, Volcán, El Valle) speech is often a bit clearer.

CHAPTER 3

El, la, and the idea of gender

Every Spanish noun is masculine or feminine. There is no secret logic that makes a table masculine and a chair feminine. Learn the little word in front with the noun, the way you learned “a pair of scissors.” English speakers slip here for years — and listeners still understand them.

	Masculine	Feminine
the	el (plural: los)	la (plural: las)
a / an	un (plural: unos)	una (plural: unas)

A few handy patterns — not rules you must defend in court:

- Words ending in **-o** are usually masculine: **el banco, el mercado, el baño.**
- Words ending in **-a** are usually feminine: **la casa, la farmacia, la cuenta.**
- Words ending in **-ción, -sión, -dad, -tad** are feminine: **la dirección, la ciudad.**
- When in doubt, English speakers default to masculine. The slips that last are almost always on feminine words. Learn **la** with those nouns and you cut the problem in half.

Professions: el and la tell you who

Some job words don't change at all. The little word in front is the gender: **el** for a man, **la** for a woman. This is the usual pattern for words ending in **-ista**.

A man	A woman	English
el dentista	la dentista	the dentist
el recepcionista	la recepcionista	the receptionist
el especialista	la especialista	the specialist

Other jobs do change the ending: **el médico / la médica, el vecino / la vecina.** Either way, listen for **el** or **la** — that is who they are.

Learn these with the article

These are the ones that do not follow the -o / -a hint. Photograph this list.

Say it this way	Why it tricks you
el día	ends in -a, still masculine
el mapa	ends in -a, still masculine
el problema	ends in -ma, still masculine
el clima	ends in -ma, still masculine
el sistema	ends in -ma, still masculine
el programa	ends in -ma, still masculine
el agua	feminine, but takes el so you don't get “la agua”
la mano	ends in -o, still feminine
la foto	short for fotografía — still feminine
la radio	ends in -o, still feminine
la moto	short for motocicleta — still feminine
el sofá	looks like -a; masculine

Making words plural

If it ends in...	Do this	Example
a vowel	add s	casa to casas, taxi to taxis
a consonant	add es	doctor to doctores, hotel to hoteles
z	change z to c, add es	lápiz to lápices

You'll use these every week

el médico	<i>the doctor (a man)</i>
la médica	<i>the doctor (a woman)</i>
la clínica	<i>the clinic</i>
el hospital	<i>the hospital</i>
la farmacia	<i>the pharmacy</i>
el mercado	<i>the market</i>
el supermercado	<i>the supermarket</i>
la cuenta	<i>the bill (or the account)</i>
el dinero	<i>money</i>
la plata	<i>money (the casual word)</i>
el vecino	<i>the neighbor (a man)</i>
la vecina	<i>the neighbor (a woman)</i>
el apartamento	<i>the apartment</i>
la casa	<i>the house</i>
la luz	<i>the power</i>
el agua	<i>the water</i>
el internet	<i>the internet</i>
el aire (acondicionado)	<i>the air conditioning</i>

Don't wait for perfect gender

If you say **el farmacia** by accident, the pharmacist will still sell you the aspirin. Listeners almost never get lost over a wrong **el** or **la**. Get the noun out. Gender can catch up later.

CHAPTER 4

Describing things

Adjectives have to match the noun: masculine or feminine, singular or plural. And they usually come after the noun, which feels backwards until it doesn't.

una casa grande	<i>a big house</i>
un café caliente	<i>a hot coffee</i>
las islas bonitas	<i>the pretty islands</i>
el banco está cerrado	<i>the bank is closed</i>

- Ends in **-o**: **alto** (masculine), **alta** (feminine), **altos / altas** (plural).
- Ends in **-e** or a consonant: same word for masculine and feminine. Only the plural changes: **grande / grandes, fácil / fáciles**.

Masculine	Feminine	English
bueno	buena	good
malo	mala	bad
grande		big
pequeño	pequeña	small
caro	cara	expensive
barato	barata	cheap
cerca		near
lejos		far
caliente		hot
frío	fría	cold
abierto	abierta	open
cerrado	cerrada	closed
ocupado	ocupada	busy or occupied
libre		free
rico	rica	delicious (food) or rich
limpio	limpia	clean
sucio	sucia	dirty

Bueno likes to jump in front

You'll hear **un buen médico** and **un mal día**. **Bueno** and **malo** often drop the **-o** and hop in front of a masculine noun. Copy what you hear.

CHAPTER 5

I, you, we

Spanish has more words for “you” than English. In Panama the map is simpler than in Spain, and **usted** will keep you out of trouble.

Spanish	English	When to use it
yo	I	Talking about yourself. Often dropped: Hablo inglés.
tú	you (friendly)	Friends, once they use tú with you.
usted	you (polite)	Your default. Shops, clinics, new people, anyone older.
él	he	About a man.
ella	she	About a woman.
nosotros	we	A mixed group, or all men.
nosotras	we	If the group is all women.
ustedes	you all	Any group. Panama does not use vosotros.
ellos	they	A mixed group, or all men.
ellas	they	If the group is all women.

Usted is not stiff here

In some countries **usted** can sound very formal. In Panama it is everyday respect. Using it with a cashier or a doctor is not cold — it is polite. If a neighbor switches to **tú**, you can switch too.

You will notice people skip **yo** and **tú** a lot. The verb ending already says who is doing the action. **Tengo una cita** is enough. You do not need **Yo tengo una cita** unless you want to emphasize I.

This, that, these, those

Spanish	English	When
este	this	Masculine, near you
esta	this	Feminine, near you
estos	these	Masculine, near you
estas	these	Feminine, near you
ese	that	Masculine, a little farther
esa	that	Feminine, a little farther
esos	those	Masculine, a little farther
esas	those	Feminine, a little farther
esto	this	A thing or idea, not a named noun
eso	that	A thing or idea, not a named noun

¿Cuánto cuesta esto?	<i>How much is this?</i>
Quiero esa, por favor.	<i>I want that one, please.</i>
Estos son mis medicamentos.	<i>These are my medicines.</i>

CHAPTER 6

Two ways to say “to be”

English has one “to be.” Spanish has two: **ser** and **estar**. English speakers grab **ser** first and overuse it for years. The work is **estar** — especially for how someone feels and whether something is open, closed, ready, or broken.

Ser — what something is (this one comes naturally)

Use **ser** for identity, origin, occupation, time, dates, and the stuff something is made of. If it answers “what is it?” or “who is it?”, you probably want **ser**.

Soy de Canadá.	<i>I'm from Canada.</i>
Soy de los Estados Unidos.	<i>I'm from the United States.</i>
Soy jubilado.	<i>I'm retired. (a man — that's who you are)</i>
Soy jubilada.	<i>I'm retired. (a woman — that's who you are)</i>
Ella es médica.	<i>She is a doctor.</i>
Somos vecinos.	<i>We're neighbors.</i>
Hoy es martes.	<i>Today is Tuesday.</i>
Son las tres.	<i>It's three o'clock.</i>
El anillo es de oro.	<i>The ring is made of gold.</i>
¿Quién es? — Es el plomero.	<i>Who is it? — It's the plumber.</i>

Estar — how or where something is (practice this one)

Location is always **estar**, even if the place never moves: **Panamá está en Centroamérica**. Feelings, health, and “how is it right now?” are **estar** too. That last group is where English speakers keep using **ser** by accident.

Estoy en David.	<i>I'm in David.</i>
Estamos en la capital.	<i>We're in Panama City.</i>
¿Cómo está usted? — Estoy bien.	<i>How are you? — I'm well.</i>
Estoy cansado.	<i>I'm tired. (a man)</i>
Estoy cansada.	<i>I'm tired. (a woman)</i>
Estoy enfermo.	<i>I'm sick. (a man)</i>
Estoy enferma.	<i>I'm sick. (a woman)</i>
El banco está cerrado. La farmacia está abierta.	<i>The bank is closed. The pharmacy is open.</i>
El baño está ocupado.	<i>The bathroom is occupied.</i>
Está listo.	<i>It's ready.</i>
La sopa está caliente. El aire no está frío.	<i>The soup is hot (right now). The A/C isn't cold.</i>
Está lloviendo.	<i>It's raining.</i>

The mix-up that actually confuses people

A wrong **el** or **la** rarely blocks meaning. Picking the wrong “to be” often does. **Soy enfermo** sounds like “I am a sick person by nature.” **Estoy enfermo** is “I'm sick (right now).” **Soy jubilado** is your identity.

ser	estar
soy	estoy
eres (tú)	estás
es (usted, él, ella)	está
somos	estamos
son (ustedes, ellos, ellas)	están

A pocket rule

Ser = what it is. **Estar** = how or where it is right now. If you can add “at the moment” in English, try **estar**.

Hay — there is / there are

One more cousin: **hay** (sounds like “eye”). It means there is or there are. It does not change for plural. Mixing up **hay** with **es** or **está** is another mix-up listeners actually feel.

Hay un banco cerca.	<i>There is a bank nearby.</i>
¿Hay una farmacia por aquí?	<i>Is there a pharmacy around here?</i>
No hay problema.	<i>No problem. (you'll hear this all day)</i>
Hay mucha gente.	<i>There are a lot of people.</i>

Hay vs. está

Hay un banco en la esquina introduces it — there is a bank. **El banco está en la esquina** locates a bank you both already have in mind. If you are asking whether something exists nearby, start with **¿Hay...?**

CHAPTER 7**Right now: the present tense**

If you get comfortable in the present, you can handle most of a regular day. Tomorrow and yesterday can piggyback on it, as you'll see in a few chapters.

Spanish verbs in the dictionary end in **-ar**, **-er**, or **-ir**. You knock that ending off and add a new one. **Usted** uses the same ending as he/she. **Ustedes** uses the same ending as they. That cuts the chart almost in half.

hablar — to speak

Person	Form
yo	hablo
tú	hablas
usted / él / ella	habla
nosotros	hablamos
ustedes / ellos / ellas	hablan

comer — to eat

Person	Form
yo	como
tú	comes
usted / él / ella	come
nosotros	comemos
ustedes / ellos / ellas	comen

vivir — to live

Person	Form
yo	vivo
tú	vives
usted / él / ella	vive
nosotros	vivimos
ustedes / ellos / ellas	viven

Hablo un poco de español.	<i>I speak a little Spanish.</i>
¿Habla inglés?	<i>Do you speak English? (usted)</i>
Vivimos en Coronado.	<i>We live in Coronado.</i>
Ellos comen a las dos.	<i>They eat at two.</i>

The present also covers things you do in general, not only this second: **Tomo café por la mañana.** I drink coffee in the morning.

Need a verb in a hurry?

You can often skip conjugating altogether: **Quiero + a verb, Necesito + a verb, Voy a + a verb.** Chapter 10 is built on that trick.

CHAPTER 8

The verbs you'll live on

A short list of slightly irregular verbs does more daily work than twenty perfectly regular ones. Learn these in the present and you will hear them everywhere.

Infinitive	yo	usted / él / ella	nosotros	ustedes
ser (to be)	soy	es	somos	son
estar (to be)	estoy	está	estamos	están
ir (to go)	voy	va	vamos	van
tener (to have)	tengo	tiene	tenemos	tienen
hacer (to do / make)	hago	hace	hacemos	hacen
poder (to be able / can)	puedo	puede	podemos	pueden
querer (to want)	quiero	quiere	queremos	quieren
decir (to say / tell)	digo	dice	decimos	dicen
venir (to come)	vengo	viene	venimos	vienen
dar (to give)	doy	da	damos	dan
ver (to see)	veo	ve	vemos	ven
saber (to know a fact)	sé	sabe	sabemos	saben

The **tú** forms (if a friend is using tú with you) usually look like the usted form plus an **s**: **vas, tienes, puedes, quieres.** The one exception here: **eres.**

Tener is bigger than “to have”

English says “I am hungry.” Spanish says “I have hunger.” Copy these as chunks.

Tengo hambre.	<i>I'm hungry.</i>
Tengo sed.	<i>I'm thirsty.</i>
Tengo calor.	<i>I'm hot.</i>
Tengo frío.	<i>I'm cold.</i>
Tengo sueño.	<i>I'm sleepy.</i>
Tengo X años.	<i>I am X years old.</i>
Tengo una cita a las diez.	<i>I have an appointment at ten.</i>
¿Tiene cambio?	<i>Do you have change?</i>

Saber vs. conocer — two kinds of knowing

¿Sabe dónde está el hospital?	<i>Do you know where the hospital is? (a fact)</i>
No sé.	<i>I don't know.</i>
¿Conoce a un buen dentista?	<i>Do you know a good dentist? (are you familiar with one)</i>
Conocemos Boquete.	<i>We know Boquete. (we've been there)</i>

Hace calor — and then some

Weather uses **hacer**: **Hace calor. Hace sol. Está lloviendo.** In Panama, **verano** is the dry season (roughly December to April) and **invierno** is the rainy season. Nobody here is talking about snow.

CHAPTER 9

I like it — start with me, not yo

English says “I like coffee.” Spanish says the coffee is pleasing to me. You will want to say “Yo gusto” (wrong). That sentence is a wrong turn. Start with **me**. The thing you like does the verb.

One thing, or more than one

Match the verb to the thing, not to you. One thing: **gusta**. Several things: **gustan**. A verb after it counts as one thing, so it stays **gusta**.

Me gusta el café.	<i>I like coffee.</i>
Me gusta Boquete.	<i>I like Boquete.</i>
Me gustan las empanadas.	<i>I like empanadas.</i>
Me gustan las islas.	<i>I like the islands.</i>
No me gusta el ruido.	<i>I don't like the noise.</i>
No me gustan los mosquitos.	<i>I don't like mosquitoes.</i>

With a verb — still gusta

Park a dictionary-form verb after **gusta**, the same way you park a noun. This is how you say you like doing something. Never “gustan bailar” (wrong) — the activity is one thing.

Me gusta bailar.	<i>I like to dance.</i>
Me gusta caminar.	<i>I like to walk.</i>
Me gusta nadar.	<i>I like to swim.</i>
No me gusta manejar.	<i>I don't like to drive.</i>
¿A usted le gusta caminar?	<i>Do you like to walk?</i>

Asking — usted first

At a restaurant or a neighbor's table, ask with **le**. That is the polite “you.”

¿Le gusta el pescado?	<i>Do you like fish?</i>
¿Le gustan las empanadas?	<i>Do you like empanadas?</i>
¿Le gusta Panamá?	<i>Do you like Panama?</i>
Sí, me gusta.	<i>Yes, I like it.</i>
No, no me gusta.	<i>No, I don't like it.</i>

Once a friend uses **tú** with you, you can ask **¿Te gusta el café?** Until then, stay with **le**.

Who is pleased

The little word in front tells who likes it. The verb still follows the thing: **gusta** or **gustan**.

English	One thing	More than one
I like	Me gusta	Me gustan
you like (tú)	Te gusta	Te gustan
you like (usted); he or she likes	Le gusta	Le gustan
we like	Nos gusta	Nos gustan
you all like; they like	Les gusta	Les gustan

Le is busy: polite “you,” or him, or her. If that is messy, name the person up front. You'll hear this when tastes differ.

A mí me gusta el café.	<i>I like coffee. (me, specifically)</i>
A usted le gusta el té.	<i>You like tea. (usted)</i>
A ella le gustan las islas.	<i>She likes the islands.</i>
Nos gusta Panamá.	<i>We like Panama.</i>

I'd like — the polite shop sentence

Learn **Me gustaría...** as a chunk, like **Quiero**. It is softer, and it is what you say at a counter. You do not need the rest of that verb. This one line will do.

Me gustaría una mesa para dos.	<i>I would like a table for two.</i>
Me gustaría ver el menú.	<i>I would like to see the menu.</i>
Me gustaría pagar con tarjeta.	<i>I would like to pay by card.</i>
¿Le gustaría un café?	<i>Would you like a coffee?</i>

The same machine

A few other verbs run backwards the same way. The thing (or the body part) does the verb. You already know one from Chapter 1: **Me duele aquí**.

Me duele la rodilla.	<i>My knee hurts.</i>
Me encanta este lugar.	<i>I love this place.</i>
Me encantan las islas.	<i>I love the islands.</i>
Me falta dinero.	<i>I'm short of money.</i>

Me encanta is the friendly “I love it” for food, towns, and weather — not usually for people. For family, **Quiero mucho a mi familia** is safer.

Don't say yo gusto

English wants “I like.” Spanish will not take “Yo gusto el café” (wrong). If you freeze, start with **Me gusta...** and name the thing. Close enough is plenty.

CHAPTER 10

Questions, “no,” and the magic five

You can live a long time on questions, a well-placed **no**, and five little helper verbs. This chapter is the Swiss Army knife.

Asking questions

Written Spanish uses two question marks: **¿ ... ?** Spoken Spanish often just uses tone. You can turn many statements into questions by lifting your voice: **¿Habla inglés?**

Word	Feminine	English	Try this
qué		what	¿Qué es esto?
quién		who	¿Quién es?
dónde		where	¿Dónde está el baño?
cuándo		when	¿Cuándo abre?
cómo		how	¿Cómo está usted?
cuánto	cuánta	how much	¿Cuánto cuesta?
cuántos	cuántas	how many	¿Cuántos años tiene?
por qué		why	¿Por qué está cerrado?
cuál		which / what (choice)	¿Cuál es su dirección?
a qué hora		at what time	¿A qué hora es la cita?

Saying no

Put **no** right before the verb: **No hablo español muy bien.** Double negatives are correct, not sloppy: **No tengo nada.** (I don't have anything.) **No hay nadie.** (There's no one.)

No entiendo.	<i>I don't understand.</i>
No sé.	<i>I don't know.</i>
No, gracias.	<i>No, thank you.</i>
Todavía no.	<i>Not yet.</i>

The magic five: want, can, need, have to, going to

Park a verb in its dictionary form after one of these, and you can talk about almost any action without conjugating the second verb. This is the cheat that fluent-looking beginners actually use.

Pattern	Example	English
Quiero + verb	Quiero pagar.	I want to pay.
Puedo + verb	Puedo esperar.	I can wait.
¿Puede...?	¿Puede ayudarme?	Can you help me?
Necesito + verb	Necesito hablar con el médico.	I need to talk to the doctor.
Tengo que + verb	Tengo que ir al banco.	I have to go to the bank.
Voy a + verb	Voy a llamar mañana.	I'm going to call tomorrow.

Quiero reservar una mesa.	<i>I want to reserve a table.</i>
No puedo caminar mucho.	<i>I can't walk very far.</i>
Necesito un taxi.	<i>I need a taxi.</i>
Tenemos que esperar.	<i>We have to wait.</i>
Vamos a comer aquí.	<i>We're going to eat here.</i>
¿Me puede escribir eso, por favor?	<i>Can you write that down for me, please?</i>

Your future tense, for now

Spanish has a “real” future tense (**hablaré, irá**). You can ignore it for months. **Voy a...** is what people actually say about later today, tomorrow, and next Tuesday.

CHAPTER 11

Yesterday, without the headache

Spanish has two everyday past tenses. English has one. That is why this chapter lasts for years. You need the short version: one past for finished events, one past for background and “used to.” The English trap is using the snapshot past for both.

The snapshot: something finished

Use this when the thing happened and it's done. Yesterday. This morning. Last Tuesday. A completed trip to the clinic.

Ayer fui al médico.	<i>Yesterday I went to the doctor.</i>
Comí pescado.	<i>I ate fish.</i>
Pagamos en efectivo.	<i>We paid in cash.</i>
¿Qué pasó?	<i>What happened?</i>

The usual forms for a few high-value verbs:

Verb	yo	tú	usted / él / ella	nosotros	ustedes
ir	fui	fuiste	fue	fuimos	fueron
ser	fui	fuiste	fue	fuimos	fueron
estar	estuve	estuviste	estuvo	estuvimos	estuvieron
tener	tuve	tuviste	tuvo	tuvimos	tuvieron
hacer	hice	hiciste	hizo	hicimos	hicieron
decir	dije	dijiste	dijo	dijimos	dijeron
venir	vine	viniste	vino	vinimos	vinieron
ver	vi	viste	vio	vimos	vieron
poder	pude	pudiste	pudo	pudimos	pudieron
dar	di	diste	dio	dimos	dieron
hablar	hablé	hablaste	habló	hablamos	hablaron
comer	comí	comiste	comió	comimos	comieron

The background: how things were

Use this for weather, age, feelings, what something used to be like, or what was going on around the main event.

Hacía mucho calor.	<i>It was really hot.</i>
Cuando vivíamos en Florida...	<i>When we used to live in Florida...</i>
Era médico.	<i>He was a doctor. (that was his profession)</i>
Estaba cansada.	<i>She was tired.</i>
Había mucha gente.	<i>There were a lot of people.</i>

Useful background forms	English
era	was (ser)
eran	were (ser)
estaba	was (estar)
estaban	were (estar)
había	there was / there were
tenía	had / used to have
hacía	was making / weather was
iba	was going / used to go
vivía	used to live / was living

The English trap

If you can add “used to” or “was ...-ing” in English, do not use the snapshot past. **Comí pescado** is “I ate fish (and I was done).” **Comía pescado** is “I used to eat fish / I was eating fish.” English speakers keep putting the snapshot where the background belongs. Listeners feel that one.

Ayer comí pescado.	<i>Yesterday I ate fish. (done)</i>
Cuando vivía en Florida, comía pescado.	<i>When I lived in Florida, I used to eat fish.</i>
Fui al médico el martes.	<i>I went to the doctor on Tuesday. (that visit)</i>
Iba al médico cada mes.	<i>I used to go to the doctor every month.</i>

If you freeze, tell the story in two strokes

Background first, snapshot second: **Estaba en la casa y se fue la luz.** I was at the house and the power went out. That pattern will carry a lot of stories.

CHAPTER 12

Please do this: commands

*You don't need the full command system. You need a short list for clinics, shops, and friends. Use the **usted** column with people you don't know well. Use the **tú** column once someone is using tú with you.*

Formal (usted)	Informal (tú)	English
Deme..., por favor.	Dame..., por favor.	Give me..., please.
Tráigame la cuenta.	Tráeme la cuenta.	Bring me the bill.
Ayúdeme, por favor.	Ayúdame, por favor.	Help me, please.
Espere un momento.	Espera un momento.	Wait a moment.
Pase, por favor.	Pasa, por favor.	Come in, please.
Sígame, por favor.	Sígueme, por favor.	Follow me, please.
Hable más despacio.	Habla más despacio.	Speak more slowly.
Escríballo, por favor.	Escríbelo, por favor.	Write it down, please.
Perdóneme.	Perdóname.	Excuse me / forgive me.
Dígame.	Dime.	Tell me.

You'll hear these said to you:

Formal (usted)	Informal (tú)	English
Tome asiento.	Toma asiento.	Have a seat.
Firme aquí.	Firma aquí.	Sign here.
Espere aquí.	Espera aquí.	Wait here.
Pase a la caja.	Pasa a la caja.	Go to the cashier.
No fume.	No fumes.	No smoking. / Don't smoke.
Siéntese, por favor.	Siéntate, por favor.	Please sit down.

How they're built, if you're curious

Usted: start with the **yo** form in the present, drop the **-o**, and add the “opposite” vowel — **hablo** to **hable**, **como** to **coma**, **vivo** to **viva**. Rebels: **tenga, venga, diga, haga, ponga, vaya, sea, esté, dé**. **Tú** yes-commands are usually the he/she present: **habla, come, vive**. Rebels: **di, haz, ve, pon, sal, sé, ten, ven**. **Tú** no-commands look like usted plus an **s**: **no fumes, no hables**.

Regálame un vaso de agua

You will hear **regalar** used for “hand me / give me,” not only for birthday presents. **¿Me regala una bolsa?** is a normal way to ask for a bag at the checkout. With a friend: **Regálame una bolsa**. They are not asking you to donate one.

CHAPTER 13

Por and para — the short version

*Both can translate as “for,” which is unhelpful. You do not need every textbook list. You need four jobs for **para** and four for **por**.*

Para — purpose, destination, deadline, recipient

Este café es para usted.	<i>This coffee is for you.</i>
Salimos para Boquete el viernes.	<i>We're leaving for Boquete on Friday.</i>
Lo necesito para mañana.	<i>I need it by tomorrow.</i>
Estudio para hablar mejor.	<i>I study in order to speak better.</i>

Por — reason, duration, through, exchange

Gracias por su ayuda.	<i>Thank you for your help.</i>
Caminamos por la playa.	<i>We walked along the beach.</i>
Estuve allí por tres días.	<i>I was there for three days.</i>
Pagué diez dólares por esto.	<i>I paid ten dollars for this.</i>
Por la mañana	<i>in the morning</i>
Por la tarde	<i>in the afternoon</i>
Por la noche	<i>in the evening</i>

Stuck?

If it means “in order to,” “by this date,” “headed to,” or “this is for that person,” try **para**. If it means “because of,” “through,” “for a stretch of time,” or “in exchange for,” try **por**. And memorize **por favor** as a chunk. Do not take it apart.

CHAPTER 14

Where things are

Location is **estar** plus a little preposition. Learn the cluster below and you can follow directions — or give them with your hands.

Spanish	English
en	in / on / at
a	to / at (with motion: ir a)
de	of / from
con	with
sin	without
cerca de	near
lejos de	far from
al lado de	next to
delante de	in front of
detrás de	behind
encima de	on top of
debajo de	under
dentro de	inside
fuera de	outside
entre	between
a la derecha	to the right
a la izquierda	to the left
derecho	straight ahead

Two fusions you'll see constantly: **a + el = al** (**Voy al banco**) and **de + el = del** (**cerca del hospital**). **A la** and **de la** stay as two words.

El banco está al lado del supermercado.	<i>The bank is next to the supermarket.</i>
Vivo cerca de la playa.	<i>I live near the beach.</i>
Está a dos cuadras.	<i>It's two blocks away.</i>
Gire a la derecha.	<i>Turn right.</i>
Vinimos de la capital.	<i>We came from Panama City.</i>

The personal “a” — when the object is a person

English speakers drop this constantly. It is a tiny **a** before a person (or a pet you treat like a person). Things do not get it. People will still understand you without it. Copy it when you can and you will sound more natural.

Busco a mi esposa.	<i>I'm looking for my wife.</i>
Busco un restaurante.	<i>I'm looking for a restaurant. (a thing — no a)</i>
¿Conoce a un buen dentista?	<i>Do you know a good dentist?</i>
Llamo a María.	<i>I'm calling María.</i>
Veo el banco.	<i>I see the bank. (a thing — no a)</i>
Quiero mucho a mi familia.	<i>I love my family a lot.</i>

CHAPTER 15

Numbers, money, and time

This is the chapter you will use at the caja, the clinic window, and the taxi door. Panama uses U.S. dollars, so the only conversion is the words.

Numbers you actually need

0	cero	1	uno	2	dos
3	tres	4	cuatro	5	cinco
6	seis	7	siete	8	ocho
9	nueve	10	diez	11	once
12	doce	13	trece	14	catorce
15	quince	16	dieciséis	17	diecisiete
18	dieciocho	19	diecinueve	20	veinte
21	veintiuno	22	veintidós	30	treinta
40	cuarenta	50	cincuenta	60	sesenta
70	setenta	80	ochenta	90	noventa
100	cien	101	ciento uno	200	doscientos
500	quinientos	1,000	mil	1,000,000	un millón

- **Uno** becomes **un** before a masculine noun: **un dólar**. **Una** before feminine: **una caja**.
- 200–900 change for gender: **doscientos dólares**, **doscientas cajas**.
- Years: 2026 is **dos mil veintiséis**.

Money

¿Cuánto cuesta?	<i>How much does it cost?</i>
¿Cuánto es?	<i>How much is it?</i>
¿A cómo?	<i>How much each? (at markets)</i>
Está muy caro.	<i>That's very expensive.</i>
¿Me puede hacer un precio?	<i>Can you do a better price?</i>
La cuenta, por favor.	<i>The bill, please.</i>
¿Tiene cambio?	<i>Do you have change?</i>
el vuelto	<i>the change you get back</i>
en efectivo	<i>in cash</i>
con tarjeta	<i>by card</i>
¿Aceptan tarjeta?	<i>Do you take cards?</i>

Dollars, balboas, and the caja

Paper money is the U.S. dollar. Coins can be U.S. or Panama's own **balboas**, which are worth exactly the same. **La caja** is the cashier. **La cola** is the line. Tipping is modest — ten percent at sit-down restaurants is a kind default if service is not already included.

What time is it?

¿Qué hora es?	<i>What time is it?</i>
Es la una.	<i>It's one o'clock. (la una is singular)</i>
Son las dos.	<i>It's two o'clock.</i>
Son las tres y media.	<i>It's 3:30.</i>
Son las cuatro y cuarto.	<i>It's 4:15.</i>
Son las diez menos diez.	<i>It's 9:50. (ten to ten)</i>
Son diez para las diez.	<i>It's 9:50. (how Panama often says it)</i>
a las nueve de la mañana	<i>at 9:00 a.m.</i>
a las siete de la noche	<i>at 7:00 p.m.</i>

Days: **lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes, sábado, domingo.** They are not capitalized. **El lunes** means on Monday; **los lunes** means on Mondays in general.

Months: **enero, febrero, marzo, abril, mayo, junio, julio, agosto, septiembre, octubre, noviembre, diciembre.** Dates go day first: **el 9 de septiembre.**

CHAPTER 16

Little words that do a lot of work

These are the glue. If you recognize them, whole sentences stop being a blur.

Spanish	English	Note
ya	already / now	Also used as “okay, got it.”
todavía	still / yet	Todavía no = not yet.
aún	still / yet	
también	also / too	
tampoco	neither / not either	The “no” version of también.
muy	very	Muy + adjective: muy caro .
mucho	a lot	Mucho + noun: mucho tráfico .
más	more	Más despacio .
menos	less	Menos hielo .
ahora	now	
ahorita	in a bit	Ahorita is famously flexible.
después	after	
luego	later	
aquí	here	
allí	there	
allá	over there	
bien	well	¿Todo bien?
mal	badly	
hoy	today	
mañana	tomorrow	Mañana is also “morning.”
ayer	yesterday	
pero	but	
porque	because	

Spanish	English	Note
entonces	so then	
siempre	always	
nunca	never	Nunca already includes the no.
casi	almost	Casi nunca = hardly ever.

Ahorita is a lifestyle

Ahorita can mean right now, in a few minutes, or later this afternoon, depending on the smile that comes with it. If you need a real time, ask: **¿A qué hora, más o menos?** Around what time?

A few tiny extras you'll hear constantly

- **-ito / -ita** makes things smaller or kinder: **momentito, cafecito, abuelita**. It is friendly, not baby talk.
- **lo** and **la** often mean “it” or “him/her,” and they sit in front of the verb: **¿Lo vio?** Did you see it? **La tengo**. I have it. If that throws you, just repeat the noun. English speakers trip here more than on verbs — recognition first is enough.
- You'll hear **se lo** a lot: **Se lo dije**. I told him/her. You do not have to build this yet. Just know it is not a new verb.
- **se** also shows up on signs: **Se vende. Se alquila. Se habla español**. For sale. For rent. Spanish spoken here.
- **Me llamo** is technically a reflexive verb. So is **Me siento mal** (I feel bad). Learn them as phrases.

CHAPTER 17

Panama Spanish, the local layer

You do not need slang to buy papayas. But a few local habits will make the country sound less like your textbook and more like the taxi.

You'll hear	What they mean
la capital	Panama City
el interior	the rest of the country, outside the city
chévere	great, cool, nice
¿Qué xopá?	What's up? (very Panama; you can just smile back)
pelao	kid / young person (a boy)
pelaíta	kid / young person (a girl)
la plata	money
un bote	a ride (¿Me da un bote?)
la bomba	the gas station (yes, also “bomb” — context will save you)
el abanico	the fan
la chitra	no-see-ums, the tiny biting bugs
diablo rojo	the old painted buses
el Metro	Panama City's subway
Metrobus	Panama City's bus system
farmacia de turno	the pharmacy on duty that night
se fue la luz	the power went out
se fue el agua	the water went out
¡Juega vivo!	be street-smart / don't get taken (also: someone working an angle)

- There is no **vos** here (that's more Costa Rica, Nicaragua, Argentina). Stick with **tú** and **usted**.
- There is no **vosotros**. Groups are **ustedes**.
- **Guagua** is not the Panama word for bus. Say **bus**.
- English sneaks in: **el parking**, **el mall**, **el email**, **okay**. You are allowed to mix a little.

- People may answer your careful Spanish with English. That is kindness, not a correction.

A note you can leave for the building manager

Estimado señor / Estimada señora:

Soy su vecino/a del apartamento _____. Se fue el agua esta mañana (or: El aire no funciona / Hay una gotera en el techo). ¿Puede ayudarnos, por favor?

Muchas gracias,

CHAPTER 18

Filling out a form

The clinic clipboard, the bank, the building office, immigration. The boxes repeat. If you know the labels, you can point — even when the clerk is talking too fast.

A form is not a conversation. You do not have to say a perfect sentence. Fill the box, or point at it and ask **¿Qué es esto?** What is this?

Who you are

On the form	English
nombre	first name
segundo nombre	middle name
apellido	last name
primer apellido	first last name
segundo apellido	second last name
nombre completo	full name
fecha de nacimiento	date of birth
lugar de nacimiento	place of birth
nacionalidad	nationality
país	country
pasaporte	passport
número de pasaporte	passport number
cédula	national ID card
número de seguro social	social security number (Panama's CSS)
sexo	sex
masculino	male
femenino	female

Spanish forms often want two last names: father's, then mother's. If you only have one, put it in **primer apellido** and leave **segundo apellido** blank — or write a dash. Your middle name goes in **segundo nombre**, not in **segundo apellido**.

On a form, U.S. nationality is **estadounidense**. **Americano** can mean the whole continent.

Dates — day first

Panama writes the day before the month. **15/03/1952** is 15 March 1952, not March 15. If you write **3/5/1952** for March 5, the form reads it as 3 May.

el 15 de marzo de 1952	<i>March 15, 1952</i>
fecha de hoy	<i>today's date</i>

Married, retired, and how to reach you

On the form	English
estado civil	marital status
soltero	single (a man)
soltera	single (a woman)
casado	married (a man)
casada	married (a woman)
viudo	widowed (a man)
viuda	widowed (a woman)
divorciado	divorced (a man)
divorciada	divorced (a woman)
ocupación	occupation
jubilado	retired (a man)
jubilada	retired (a woman)
dirección	address
provincia	province
distrito	district (like a county)
corregimiento	neighborhood district
edificio	building
apartamento	apartment
teléfono	phone
celular	cell phone
correo electrónico	email
firma	signature
fecha	date

Panama addresses go big to small: **provincia** (Panamá, Chiriquí), then **distrito** (Panamá, Boquete), then **corregimiento** (Bella Vista, Bajo Boquete). Street numbers are rare — a building name and a landmark do the work.

Seguro social here means Panama's **Caja de Seguro Social**, not your U.S. number. If you are not in it, say **No tengo seguro social**. and leave the box blank.

Firma is where you sign — your usual signature, not your name in print. If the form says **letra de molde** or **letra de imprenta**, print. Don't use cursive in the other boxes.

No cédula yet

A **cédula** is the Panamanian ID card. Until you have one, the answer is your passport. Write the passport number in that box if they let you, or say: **No tengo cédula. Tengo pasaporte.**

At the window

Spanish	English
¿Qué es esto?	What is this?
¿Dónde firmo?	Where do I sign?
¿Puede ayudarme con este formulario?	Can you help me with this form?
No tengo cédula. Tengo pasaporte.	I don't have a cédula. I have a passport.
Solo tengo un apellido.	I only have one last name.
No tengo seguro social.	I don't have Panamanian social security.
Soy ciudadano estadounidense.	I am a U.S. citizen. (a man)
Soy ciudadana estadounidense.	I am a U.S. citizen. (a woman)
¿Cómo se escribe?	How is that spelled?
¿Con bolígrafo negro?	With a black pen?

If you freeze

Show the passport. Point at the box. Say **¿Qué es esto?** A kind clerk would rather fill it with you than watch you guess.

CHAPTER 19

Phrasebook for a regular week

Keep this chapter on your phone. Read the Spanish out loud once before you walk in. Close enough is plenty.

Greetings and good manners

Spanish	English
Buenos días.	Good morning.
Buenas tardes.	Good afternoon.
Buenas noches.	Good evening.
¿Cómo está usted? — Bien, gracias. ¿Y usted?	How are you? — Fine, thanks. And you?
Mucho gusto.	Nice to meet you.
El gusto es mío.	The pleasure is mine.
¿Cómo se llama? — Me llamo...	What's your name? — My name is...
Con permiso.	Excuse me (passing through).
Perdón.	Sorry / pardon me.
Por favor.	Please.
Gracias.	Thank you.
De nada.	You're welcome.
Hasta luego.	See you later.
Nos vemos.	See you.
Que le vaya bien.	Take care.

When the Spanish is too fast

Spanish	English
No hablo español muy bien.	I don't speak Spanish very well.
¿Habla inglés?	Do you speak English?
Más despacio, por favor.	More slowly, please.
¿Puede repetir?	Can you repeat that?
¿Cómo se dice ... en español?	How do you say ... in Spanish?
¿Qué significa esto?	What does this mean?
¿Me lo puede escribir?	Can you write it down for me?
Un momento, por favor. Voy a usar el traductor.	One moment, please. I'm going to use the translator.

At the clinic

Spanish	English
Tengo una cita a las diez.	I have a ten o'clock appointment.
Me duele aquí.	It hurts here.
Me duele la cabeza.	I have a headache.
Me duele el estómago.	My stomach hurts.
Me duele la espalda.	My back hurts.
Me duele la rodilla.	My knee hurts.
Tengo mareos.	I have dizziness.
Tengo fiebre.	I have a fever.
Tengo tos.	I have a cough.
Tengo náuseas.	I have nausea.
Me siento mareado.	I feel dizzy. (a man)
Me siento mareada.	I feel dizzy. (a woman)
Me siento mal.	I feel unwell.
Soy alérgico a la penicilina.	I'm allergic to penicillin. (a man)
Soy alérgica a la penicilina.	I'm allergic to penicillin. (a woman)
Tomo estos medicamentos. (show the list)	I take these medications.
Tengo presión alta.	I have high blood pressure.
Tengo diabetes.	I have diabetes.
Soy jubilado.	I'm retired. (a man)
Soy jubilada.	I'm retired. (a woman)
¿Es grave?	Is it serious?
¿Qué tengo?	What do I have?
¿Cuándo vuelvo?	When do I come back?

At the pharmacy

Spanish	English
¿Tiene algo para el dolor?	Do you have something for pain?
¿Tiene algo para el resfriado?	Do you have something for a cold?
¿Tiene algo para la alergia?	Do you have something for allergies?
Necesito esto. (show paper or bottle)	I need this.
¿Es con receta?	Is it by prescription?
Una caja, por favor.	One box, please.
¿Cómo se toma?	How do you take it?
¿Cada cuántas horas?	Every how many hours?
Con comida.	With food.
Con el estómago vacío.	On an empty stomach.

Eating out

Spanish	English
Una mesa para dos, por favor.	A table for two, please.
El menú, por favor.	The menu, please.
¿Qué recomienda?	What do you recommend?
Agua sin gas.	Still water.
Agua con gas.	Sparkling water.
Sin hielo, por favor.	No ice, please.
Sin picante, por favor.	Not spicy, please.
Está delicioso.	It's delicious.
Para llevar.	To go.
La cuenta, por favor.	The bill, please.
¿Está incluida la propina?	Is the tip included?

At home with a plumber, electrician, or gardener

Spanish	English
Se fue la luz.	The power went out.
Se fue el agua.	The water went out.
Se fue el internet.	The internet went out.
El aire no enfría.	The air conditioning isn't cooling.
Hay una gotera en el techo.	There's a leak in the roof.
El inodoro no funciona.	The toilet doesn't work.
¿Puede arreglarlo?	Can you fix it?
¿Cuánto cobra?	How much do you charge?
¿Puede venir hoy?	Can you come today?
¿Puede venir mañana?	Can you come tomorrow?
¿A qué hora?	At what time?

Getting around

Spanish	English
¿Está libre?	Are you free? (taxi)
Al Centro Médico Paitilla, por favor.	To Paitilla Medical Center, please.
¿Cuánto es hasta...?	How much is it to...?
Aquí está bien. Gracias.	Here is fine. Thank you.
¿Dónde está la parada del bus?	Where is the bus stop?
¿Dónde está la estación del Metro?	Where is the Metro station?
Un taxi, por favor.	A taxi, please.

Neighbors and small talk

Spanish	English
Somos vecinos. Vivimos en...	We're neighbors. We live in...
¿Me puede recomendar un buen dentista?	Can you recommend a good dentist?
¿Me puede recomendar un buen restaurante?	Can you recommend a good restaurant?
¿Me puede recomendar un buen plomero?	Can you recommend a good plumber?
Está muy rico el café.	This coffee is really good.
¡Qué calor!	So hot!
Que descanse.	Rest well. (a warm evening goodbye)

Emergencies

Spanish	English
¡Ayuda, por favor!	Help, please!
Llame a una ambulancia.	Call an ambulance.
Necesito un médico ahora.	I need a doctor now.
Me siento muy mal.	I feel very ill.
Hubo un accidente.	There was an accident.
Policía, por favor.	Police, please.

911 works in Panama

You can dial 911 for police, fire, and ambulance. If you can, also tell someone nearby: **Llame al nueve once, por favor.**

KEEP THIS PAGE

Cheat sheets

The whole booklet in a few little boxes. Take a photo of this page.

Ser vs. estar vs. hay

Use	When	Example
ser	who / what / origin / time / job	Soy jubilado. Es martes. Somos de Ohio.
estar	where / how you feel / open-closed	Estoy en David. Está cerrado. Estoy cansado.
hay	there is / there are	¿Hay un cajero cerca?

Two pasts

If English can say...	Use	Example
I did it (and it finished)	snapshot	Ayer fui al médico. Comí pescado.
I used to / I was -ing	background	Cuando vivía en Florida... Hacía calor.

The sentence machines

Start with	Add	You get
Quiero...	a noun or a verb	Quiero agua. Quiero pagar.
Necesito...	a noun or a verb	Necesito ayuda. Necesito descansar.
¿Puede...?	a verb	¿Puede repetir? ¿Puede ayudarme?
Tengo que...	a verb	Tengo que ir al banco.
Voy a...	a verb	Voy a llamar mañana.
Me gusta...	one thing, or a verb	Me gusta el café. Me gusta bailar.
Me gustan...	more than one thing you like	Me gustan las islas.
¿Dónde está...?	a place or thing	¿Dónde está la caja?
¿Cuánto cuesta...?	a thing	¿Cuánto cuesta esto?
Busco a...	a person	Busco a María. (things skip the a)

Tricky gender, with the article: **el día, el mapa, el problema, el agua, la mano, la foto.**

POCKET PAGE

If you only carry one page

Fold this. Keep it in your wallet. Point at a line if the words will not come.

Spanish	English
Más despacio, por favor.	A little slower, please.
No hablo español muy bien.	I don't speak Spanish well.
¿Me puede ayudar?	Can you help me?
¿Habla inglés?	Do you speak English?
¿Cuánto cuesta?	How much is it?
Quiero esto, por favor.	I want this, please.
¿Dónde está el baño?	Where is the bathroom?
Tengo una cita.	I have an appointment.
Me duele aquí.	It hurts here.
Se fue la luz.	The power went out.
Se fue el agua.	The water went out.
¿Puede repetir?	Can you repeat that?
Gracias.	Thank you.
Por favor.	Please.
Que le vaya bien.	Take care.
Llame a una ambulancia.	Call an ambulance.

Ánimo. You've got this.

911 works in Panama. Say **Llame al nueve once, por favor.** Use **usted** with people you don't know well. Close enough is plenty.